

# Allegheny West

## Magazine

Volume 14, No. 80  
October/November 2012

FREE Direct Mail  
Community Publication

WEST ALLEGHENY EDITION

In Our  
**14th Year**  
Serving Our  
Community



## **Faith in Action**

### **Standing Ready to Help Others**

**The Town That Oil Built**  
**Centennial Ladies: Nettie and Alice Turn 100**  
**Red Rider Raises Flag for Diabetes**  
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**WA**

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One of 3 Editions Serving 14 Airport Area Communities  
WEST ALLEGHENY EDITION SERVES THE COMMUNITIES OF FINDLAY, NORTH FAYETTE, OAKDALE,  
STURGEON, McDONALD AND WEST ALLEGHENY SCHOOL DISTRICT  
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# *From the* PUBLISHER & EDITORS

## It's the West Allegheny Way



Recently, there has been an upsurge in need in the West Allegheny community.

First, the West Allegheny Food Pantry has issued a call for help. Their pantry supplies and financial resources are draining more quickly than they can help the clients they serve.

Second, a new arm of Faith in Action has evolved out of Clinton United Presbyterian Church. The organization currently has about 20 volunteers ready to help drive residents to their doctor and other appointments, get their groceries, or assist with other day-to-day tasks where they need driven. However, this wonderful group of community volunteers wants to get the word out that they are available to serve those in need. Read their story in this issue.

There are others who share their story of community support during times of loss and survival. The community rose to the occasion to support a blood drive to help young Gabby Holtz. Read Todd Kosenina's story following his tragic accident last year, and read the heartfelt thank you from one resident giving credit to the North Fayette Township Police Department and her neighbors when her dog was lost.

What a wonderful community to live in. Calls for help are put out there, many respond, and this corner of the world is a better place because of it. It's the West Allegheny way.

Pat Jennette, Publisher & Editor

## Reflecting on the Community's Oil History

Not long ago I was talking to Tim Thomassy, McDonald's former city council president, about how this little neck of the woods that this magazine covers used to be a veritable Saudi Arabia. Turns out, a huge oilfield used to underlie it, and some think, still does. For a time, it was a huge center for petroleum production. Yet, few mentions are made in the history books, and Tim says that whenever he was in school – back when they taught Pennsylvania history – no mention was ever made of it.

Not long ago, he got interested in this topic and started fishing through archives looking for more. He'd actually get really excited when, while looking through some old newspapers on the microfiche machine, he'd pull something out of the haystack. I knew just what he meant. It's one of the aspects of writing that I enjoy, going out there, looking under rocks, turning up things no one knew existed. Tim assembled what he found into an exhibit at the McDonald trail station along the Panhandle Trail. Earlier this year, he secured the historical designation marker that was dedicated this summer. Next time you're there, you should check it out.

For this issue, I got to explore our area's historical and not often talked about ties to the petroleum industry. It seems relevant, given the current energy boom our area is experiencing. We're hoping to look more into this subject in future issues and in the different communities we cover.

Doug Hughey, Assistant Editor



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# The Town That OIL BUILT

BY DOUG HUGHEY

PHOTOS BY  
CHRISTOPHER ROLINSON,  
DOUG HUGHEY,  
AND HISTORICAL MEMORABILIA



**ABOVE:** Spouting oil well derrick in McDonald, late 1800s. (from "The Oil Well Driller: History of the Oil Industry of the World").



**ABOVE:** Attending the dedication in September of the historic marker identifying McDonald as a major player in the oil industry are, left to right, State Representative Jesse White; Tim Thomassy, former McDonald Councilperson; Kathy J. Flaherty, ABARTA Oil and Gas; Dave Nickscic, president, McDonald Area Redevelopment Committee; Marilou Ritchie, President, McDonald Borough Council; Terry Bennett, McDonald Mayor; Andrew Masich, President and CEO, Heinz History Center. PHOTO BY DOUG HUGHEY

Over the past three years, Pennsylvania has experienced a boom in natural gas exploration, driven as much by technological advances in a drilling technique known as hydraulic fracturing as markets for cheap energy and plastics. Hydraulic fracturing involves using large amounts of pressure, chemicals, sand and water to free natural gas from shale deposits thousands of feet below the surface. In communities across Pennsylvania, the economic impact from natural gas drilling operations has been significant and measurable.

For many communities in southwestern Pennsylvania, however, this most recent boom in energy exploration is hardly their first. The region has long been a source of coal, and many communities were introduced to the petroleum industry as early as the late 19th century, back when the U.S. was still a major world oil producer, and western Pennsylvania its single largest oil producing region.

For a time, a feverish oil boom descended on an area bordering on Allegheny and Washington County, which encompassed parts of North Fayette, Moon, Robinson and Coraopolis. In less than three years, over a thousand wells were sunk into the area,

swelling Pennsylvania's annual production to an all-time high of 31.4 million barrels. Just three miles across at its widest point, and about 11 miles long, the field produced 12 million barrels in a twelve-month period, due in part to gushers that set initial production records still standing in the Appalachian Basin today. Called McDonald, the field draws its name from an unsuspecting farming and coal mining community sitting at its center.

Decades before the advent of the Model T, when a byproduct of petroleum distillation known as gasoline was dumped in rivers, most oil produced in Pennsylvania was sold as kerosene, supplying markets across Europe and as far away as Russia. A new middle class emerging from the industrial revolution created a domestic market for a range of petroleum-based products, to which Pennsylvania crude, high as it was in paraffins, and low in impurities, was particularly suited. From it, companies produced everything from bubble gum to machine lubricants.

By the time the McDonald field was being tapped, though, geologists with the United States Geological Survey were warning that the state's reserves had become tenuous. Those reports fueled a new breed of muckraking journalists in New York, who decried the nation's growing dependence on a limited



**RIGHT, TOP:** The old train station in McDonald, from the collection of Mike Mitko. Note the oil wells dotting the landscape in the background.

**RIGHT, BOTTOM:** This photo shows the interior of H.W. Rank's blacksmith shop in McDonald, used for making oil well tools. (from "The Oil Well Driller: History of the Oil Industry of the World").



Collection of Mike Mitko

natural resource controlled by a consolidated sphere of wealth. It was a characterization of the early petroleum industry, formulated largely by events in Western Pennsylvania, that would stick with it to this day.

Standard Oil, led by legendary industrialist John D. Rockefeller, encompassed a vast trust of interests exacting near absolute control over the transportation, processing, and sale of Pennsylvania crude. From afar, the company nickel and dined producers in the oil drilling regions, where profits were scarce, swindlers were common, and drilling was driven not by geologists, but "scouts" hired to spy on rivals, and wildcatters with a so-called nose for finding oil.

In 1891, a wildcatter named John H. Galey, following reports of oil near McDonald, sunk a well into a sandstone formation a little over 2,000 feet below the surface. It was considerably deeper than the average depth of most wells drilled towards the beginning of Pennsylvania's oil boom, and turned out to be the single largest producing oil well yet discovered. A boom descended thereafter, and exemplified everything that was both great and terrible about the modern petroleum industry.

\*\*\*\*\*

If nine-year-old Kate Campbell wasn't in hell, then she was sure that this was what it most surely would be like, because it resembled very closely the version described to her in Sunday school class.

The flame shooting into the air illuminated the dark town of McDonald with an alarming and ominous orange glow. A gusher of an oil well producing upwards of 100 barrels per hour had ignited when an ember wafted off a train passing on the nearby Panhandle Rail Line. It was a possibility the well's owners had failed to account for when placing the derrick. As a result, for the next six days, they and the rest of the town watched as an estimated 14,400 barrels went up in smoke. Even with oil fetching a mere \$.56 at the time, it was still a loss of \$8,064, or over \$190 thousand today.

Before the advent of modern zoning laws, or any type of environmental regulations impeding the feverish oil boom sweeping the region, little care had been paid to the placement of many of the dozens of wells drilled in the borough of McDonald. By late 1891, derricks peppered the landscape, towering in backyards and town lots, sometimes mere feet from houses and buildings. One was even erected next to the United Presbyterian Church. Covered in an oily sheen, the *McDonald Outlook* described the church as "blackened... like some medieval ruins."

Spraying oil at times poured off roofs like rain, pooling and soaking into the ground and running into Robinson Run, where



more was at one time believed to have flowed than water. One opportunistic individual named W.P. Rend, reported *The Outlook*, made \$20,000 – the equivalent of \$479 thousand today – simply by damming up the stream and skimming off the oil. A scarcity of water, coupled with the plummeting price of petroleum, led one reporter from *Frank Lesley's Weekly* to report in 1892 that it in McDonald, it was now possible to trade a barrel of water for a barrel of oil.

"No borough ever made such a mistake as this when it allowed the derricks into the borough," commented *The Outlook* that same year.

Drillers lined up rigs along property lines, as if not just to protect their own leases, but to also tap into their neighbors'. It was a race that had been played out often enough across Western Pennsylvania, with winners recovering as much oil as possible before prices plummeted, or the field ran dry, and the rest losing fortunes. As in other fields, *Frank Lesley's Weekly* reported that in McDonald, "...only a handful will come out ahead."

In September of 1891, the McDonald field reached a production level of 13,000 barrels per day, and by November 5, was gushing 84,300 barrels per day. Much of that production came from within and around McDonald itself. In just six months, the number of wells across the field had exploded, from two to roughly 300. McDonald's central rail line now played a vital role, as Standard committed its vast resources. An average of 150 tons of pipeline and materials for holding tanks was shipped in daily. Shops building tanks worked over night, and men capable of assembling them were brought in from as far away as New York and Chicago.

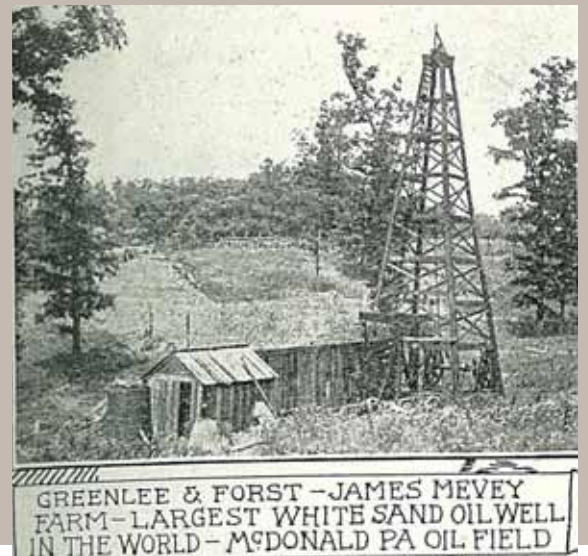
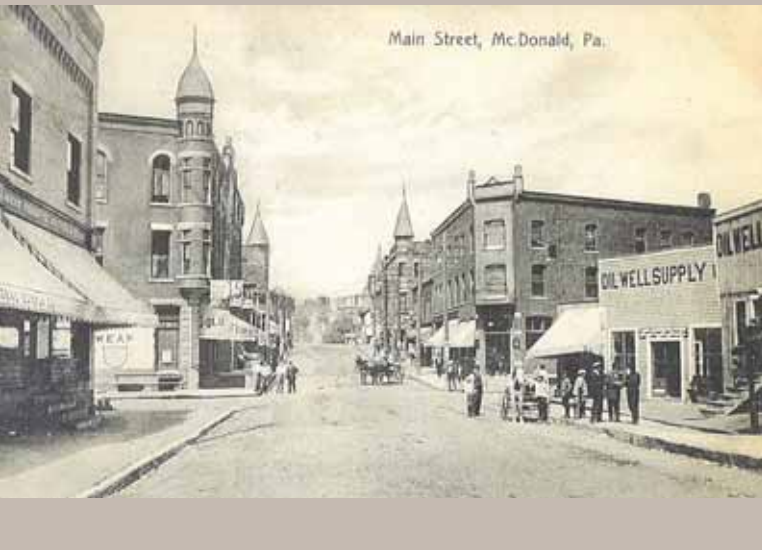
McDonald's population exploded, from about 1,500 to 10,000



**BELOW:** From a post card displaying Main Street in McDonald during the oil boom, circa 1911.

**RIGHT:** The James Mevey Farm sported the largest white sand oil well in the world in McDonald. (from "The Oil Well Driller: History of the Oil Industry of the World").

**BOTTOM:** Landscape of the town of McDonald during the oil surge. Note the numerous oil derricks along the landscape. (from "The Oil Well Driller: History of the Oil Industry of the World").



*Disturbed our rest in the midnight hour  
As men drilled and bored to find the oil  
That was hidden beneath our garden soil.*

people. Its new, eclectic population consisted of oil workers, wildcatters, speculators, and curious sightseers. Hotels opened to serve them, and so did illegal speakeasies, which by 1892 numbered more than any other town in Washington County. *The Outlook* complained about the frequent fights that broke out in such establishments, where forward thinking barkeeps had installed screens over the bars to shield them when the bottles started flying. Temperance became the subject of Sunday sermons, and the newspaper filled its pages with court announcements involving arrests over the illegal proffering liquor.

The biggest concern first and foremost for many residents, however, was the devastating fire that many were sure was imminent. In a poem later printed in the *McDonald Record-Outlook*, former resident and schoolteacher Alice May describes how such fears pervaded everyday life:

*For derricks rose up almost in a night  
And turned the town into one of fright.  
For time and time again the cry of FIRE*

When a Standard pipeline running to the United Presbyterian Church's well broke, it started a fire that consumed one house, but spared others. Residents brought the occasional lawsuit against drillers for damaged roofs and property, but by 1892, as derricks began disappearing from the landscape, *The Outlook* expressed a sense of relief:

"By great good luck we are now almost through...without a disastrous fire," though the boom had, "cost some of our citizens a world of trouble and not a little money."

That fragile sense of security was shaken on July 4 when oil workers set off nitroglycerin on a nearby hillside. More fires were still to come.

In 1893, crowds rushed through a torrential downpour after a lightening bolt ignited an 800-barrel holding tank on the Ed McDonald farm. While some men worked to build berms against flowing oil, others gawked at the traveling tornados of fire it produced.

A year later, when two boilers exploded on the James Moore farm 3½ miles outside of town, residents looked around the immediate vicinity for the cause. When a well caught fire on North McDonald Street in 1901, it left residents watching helplessly as the flames encroached on a line of nearby homes.

As in other boomtowns across Pennsylvania, the economic impact was dramatic, as *The Outlook* points out:







**ABOVE:** South West Penn's pipelines at Gregg's Station. (from "The Oil Well Driller: History of the Oil Industry of the World").

"McDonald has never before shown such signs of permanent prosperity...Men are now willing to put their money into new buildings and we have many fine residences going up...A year of Hades we've had; we may hope for a thousand of peace and prosperity now."

By 1892, the town not only already had a number of hotels, including the Valentour and Buchheit, but also the First National Bank of McDonald, and a growing S.H. Cook business block. B.D. Tillinghast's machine shop had settled in town after starting out in Oil City towards the beginning of the state's oil boom. In 1895, the town's central lumberyard changed hands and became the McCarty and Robb Lumber Dealers.

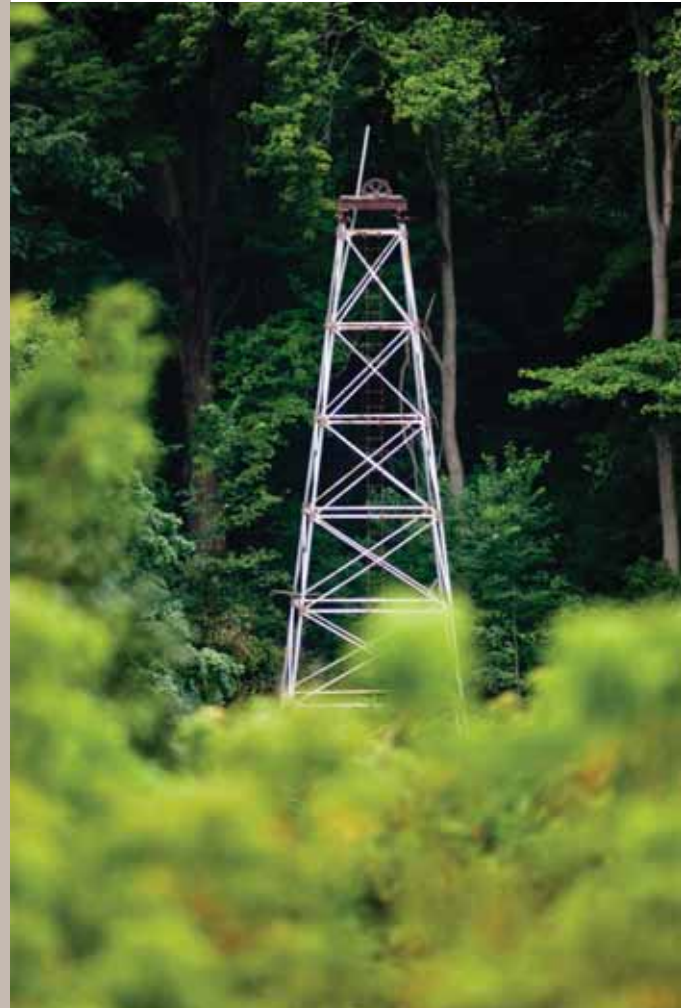
By 1893, the Light, Heat and Power Company supplied the town with electricity, and by 1894, there was a new waterworks, a new fire hose company, and a modern, \$25,000 schoolhouse. The United Presbyterian Church moved out of their old, oil-soaked church, and constructed a new brick sanctuary using royalties from its oil wells – both which turned out to be gushers producing 50 barrels per hour – at the corner of Lincoln and Station Streets. The First Presbyterian Church, likewise, constructed a new brick church. On South McDonald Street, the large, brick, multi-story Shane Cook and Valentour Thomasse buildings lined either side by 1910. By then, a trolley line also ran to Oakdale, and speakeasies founded during the boom had become legitimate, licensed establishments in hotels.

"McDonald is now one of the best towns in Washington County," so goes a description of the town published in the 1910 book, History of Washington County. "There are paved streets, substantial business blocks, handsome residences, two electric light plants, and a water works and the inhabitants enjoy all the conveniences of modern life."

Some Pennsylvania oil boomtowns had been abandoned when their fields ran dry, or worse. Among the more talked about was Pit Hole, outside of Titusville, where town property sold for millions one year, and buildings were burned to collect on insurance payouts the next. The amount of development in the years following McDonald's boom indicates the direction its residents wanted to take with theirs. McDonald, and the field bearing its name, had made national news, with gushers large enough to prompt the first real threat to Standard's hegemony, in the form of a multi-million dollar pipeline construction project headed by William L. Mellon. Between Venice and Coraopolis, 1,640 wells were drilled into the field, which by the turn of the century had few if any new ones. Pennsylvania's overall annual production sagged, then leveled, from over 31 million in 1891, to a little over 12 million.

Earlier this year, an official Pennsylvania State Historical Marker was dedicated to commemorate the McDonald Oil Field. A plaque now sits at Heritage Park along Lincoln Avenue just outside of downtown. During the dedication, Tim Thomassy, whose grandmother Kate Campbell recounted the incident of the Cook well fire she witnessed to him, pointed out that at one time, the first oil wells in McDonald could be seen and heard on a nearby hillside. Now that they're gone, what remains is the town that oil built.

# Oil Wells Still





# I Dot the Local Countryside



**ABOVE AND LEFT:** You see them in unexpected places, and in some cases, they sit alongside the road as you drive by them. They're oil wells, and they represent remnants of a time in western Pennsylvania history when the oil boom defined how some of this area secured its place in history due to the economic boom the oil wells brought. Many of the local wells still put out oil, and are owned by individuals who tap their reserves regularly. These photos around the airport area communities were taken by photographer Christopher Rolinson, a photography professor at Point Park University and owner of StartPoint Media. Can you identify where they are?



# Allegheny West

## Magazine

MONTOUR EDITION

Vol. 10, No. 56  
November/December 2012

FREE Direct Mail  
Community Publication

**SHOP THE NEIGHBORHOOD  
HOLIDAY GIFT GUIDE INSIDE!**

***Oil Well History Helped Define This Region***

**Montour Alumnus Brings Entertainment**

**to North Fayette with Latitude 40**

***Branching Out to Tell Ingram's Story***

Montour School  
District News



Pg. 14



One of 3 Editions Serving 14 Airport Area Communities  
MONTOUR EDITION SERVES THE COMMUNITIES OF INGRAM, KENNEDY, PENNSBURY, ROBINSON, THORNBURG & MONTOUR SCHOOL DISTRICT  
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# Oil Wells Helped Define This Region

For the past four years, the U.S. has experienced a boom in natural gas exploration, due in part to advancements in techniques allowing drillers to burrow sideways through relatively narrow layers of rock thousands of feet below the surface. Coupled with a process known as hydraulic fracturing, which employs massive amounts of pressurized sand, water, and chemicals to break apart rock layers, drillers have recovered copious quantities of natural gas; so much now that methane rivals coal as the country's primary energy source.

As methane prices have plummeted, however, drillers have started focusing on areas like southwestern Pennsylvania, where valuable pentanes with prices tied to oil, such as propane, butane, and ethane, intermix with methane. Processed, these pentanes can be used to produce consumer

products from plastics to tires.

A hundred years ago, oil speculators descending on parts of Robinson and Moon townships were also searching for the raw building blocks for consumer products, at that time being demanded by markets arising from the industrial revolution.

Decades before the advent of the Model T, when a byproduct of petroleum distillation known as gasoline was dumped in rivers, most of the oil produced in Pennsylvania was being sold as kerosene to markets as far away as Europe and Russia. Packed with hydrogen-based paraffins, and low in impurities, Pennsylvania crude was suited to a range of products, and from it companies made everything from bubblegum to machine lubricants. Some Pennsylvania-based motor oil companies still deal largely if not exclusively in oil being produced by century-old wells like those populating the area today.

By the time oil wells were being drilled on farms lying along present-day Steubenville Pike, a feverish, decades-old oil boom had already swept across western Pennsylvania. In the wake of that boom, geologists with the United States Geological Survey were beginning to warn that the state's reserves had become tenuous, fueling a new breed of muckraking journalists in New York who decried the nation's growing dependence on a limited natural resource controlled by a consolidated sphere of wealth. It was a characterization of the early petroleum industry, formulated largely by criticism of the monopolizing operations of John D. Rockefeller's Standard Oil in western Pennsylvania, that





# Wells Still Dot the Local Countryside



**ABOVE AND LEFT:** You see them in unexpected places, and in some cases, they sit alongside the road as you drive by them. They're oil wells, and they represent remnants of a time in western Pennsylvania history when the oil boom defined how some of this area secured its place in history due to the economic boom the oil wells brought. Many of the local wells still put out oil, and are owned by individuals who tap their reserves regularly. These photos around the airport area communities were taken by photographer Christopher Rolinson, a photography professor at Point Park University and owner of StartPoint Media. Can you identify where they are?



persists to this day.

When oil was found in parts of Robinson Township in 1888, it set off a short-lived boom across Moon and Crafton. It was just the tip of the iceberg, however, as just a few miles south gushers set initial production records still standing in the Appalachian Basin today. By 1891, drillers were producing from an area stretching from Venice to Neville Island, recovering 12 million barrels of oil in a 12-month period. Pennsylvania's annual production swelled to an all-time high of 31.4 million barrels, as drillers tapped into what turned out to be one of the last great oil fields in Pennsylvania history.

Events occurring about 390 million years ago that formed the Marcellus Shale, which is driving today's natural gas boom, says Dr. John Harper of the Pennsylvania Geological Survey, are the same ones responsible for forming the natural oil reservoirs that attracted oil speculators to the area over a hundred years ago.

\* \* \* \* \*

The earth had moved. It had buckled, folded, and traveled. The Acadian Mountains had risen in the east, and to the west, the floor of a shallow sea had formed. Algae had settled, along with anaerobic bacteria and pieces of ancient marine life, into a dark, oxygenless environment carpeted by thick, putrid mud.

Further west, the sea floor had risen gently, covered in white sands of quartz and ground-up shells. Over millions of years, water had advanced and receded numerous times, burying successive layers of sand, gravel, and mud. When the continents of Africa and North America collided 115 million years later, the Appalachian Mountains rose to heights rivaling the Himalayas, sending shockwaves through present-day Washington and Allegheny counties in the form of gentle rises and dips.

The sea floor was buried, its mud compressed into flaky shale. Organic matter, preserved by the lack of oxygen, had disintegrated into long-chained, hydrogen-based petroleum and natural gas. Under enormous pressures, oil and gas had seeped through thousands of feet of rock, collecting in sandy, porous layers; most in the gentle rises undulating westward from the Appalachians.

In 1890, near such a rise in a part of Allegheny County south of the Ohio River, oil rigs were being raised across parts of Moon and Crafton. About 350 wells were drilled in the area, after the Fort Pitt Gas Company discovered oil just east of the town of Moon Run. About three years prior, the Philadelphia Gas Company had also struck oil near Moon Run; an occurrence that went by without much notice. However, at the time the company was feeding natural gas to hundreds of miles of pipelines recently installed throughout the city of Pittsburgh.

Both wells had been drilled on the side of a promising rise. But drillers descending on parts of Moon and Crafton had missed this mark, despite an increasing awareness of where it was located and the likelihood of oil pooling beneath it.

At the time, entire towns were growing up around feeding coal to the coke ovens driving Pittsburgh's burgeoning steel industry. A shallow coal seam cropped out of the side of Mt. Washington, and miners had learned to follow it along the gentle rises and dips in the area.

Around that time, too, a geologist named Israel C. White had proven that oil pooled in such a rise. After putting his money where his mouth was, he invested in an oil company tapping

gushers in West Virginia. Geologists like Dr. White, however, were less common in the early oil producing regions than wildcatters with a so-called nose for finding oil, and "scouts" hired to spy on rival drillers.

In 1890, at the height of activity in Moon and Crafton, two oil speculators named N.D. Jones and J.M. Patterson sunk a well on a farm that once sat behind where the United Presbyterian Church does today.

Whether Jones and Patterson realized that they were situated on top of a promising rise or had done any kind of geological analysis is uncertain. They did, however, sink their well deeper than any other up to that point in Allegheny County, and, at 2,000 feet, had tapped into a yet undiscovered formation. By 2,200 feet, their well was flowing at 25 barrels per hour, filling a tank with 600 barrels in a single day. Of the ten additional wells Jones and Patterson drilled on the farm, the largest had an initial production of 125 barrels per hour.

The volume alone of that first well was significant enough for the Oil City Derrick to report on, let alone the depth and location, which indicated the apparent discovery of an oil-rich geological formation.

A half dozen miles southwest, where oil had concentrated in this structure, a well was sunk on the Mevey Farm outside of the town of McDonald. It produced volumes eight times the largest struck on the McCurdy Farm.

Both areas had benefitted from a robust agrarian economy that had suffered in the years following the Civil War, with the introduction of competition via rail lines into western territories. Derricks peppering the countryside thus provided a new source of income for these farms, which also hired miners eking out a living in the shadow of the company store.

Not everyone with a piece of land in the area struck it rich, however. One who did, according to Robinson Township's Bicentennial Book, was a Forest Grove school janitor named John McKown. In 1892, John made \$75,000 on a single oil transaction; the equivalent of almost \$2 million today.

As activity in the McCurdy field grew, it attracted out-of-towners who found work in the oil fields, and who went on to establish roots that remained for another hundred years. Among them was Elise McCormick's father, who moved her family into an oil company house when she was just a baby. In an interview published in the bicentennial book, she recounts playing in the town's muddy streets, which remained unpaved until the 1930s.

David Gailey, a superintendent overseeing the oil fields, took up residence in a house on the McCurdy farm. His prominence, and the increasing importance of the industry, may be expressed by the fact that the town's name was eventually changed from Palmersville to Gayly. According to Robinson's bicentennial book, the small town that sits at the corner of Steubenville Pike and Church Hill Road, just a few hundred yards from where David once lived, was named, "after a prominent local oil operator by that name."

Another mark the industry left is the United Presbyterian Church. In 1993, the church's bicentennial chairwoman, the late Leona Scott, told the "Pittsburgh Post-Gazette" that it had been built with royalties from coal and oil mining, about ten years after oil was first struck on the adjacent property.



# Allegheny West

## Magazine

MOON EDITION

Volume 8, No. 44  
January/February 2013

FREE Direct Mail  
Community Publication



### Oil Well History Helped Define This Region

### Official Moon Area School District Annual Report

One of 3 Editions Serving 14 Airport Area Communities  
MOON EDITION SERVES THE COMMUNITIES OF CRESCENT, MOON & MOON AREA SCHOOL DISTRICT  
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# PUBLISHER & EDITOR'S

## Notes

### Hope We Are Serving You Well



The holidays have passed once again, and another new year is upon us. We are all most likely making our resolutions and setting our goals for the year.

Here at *Allegheny West Magazine*, we're taking a moment to look back on the year and review what we accomplished, both as a publication and as a business.

What did we do well? Where did we fall short? What can we do better? Looking at ourselves during 2012 helps us to set new goals for 2013. We are always open to suggestions for improvement, story ideas, and more. From our first issue in 1999 until now, in 2013, our goal has always been to be a community connector, a liaison to share good news, information, and announcements that are important to you.

That goal will remain unchanged in 2013 as we maintain our mission statement, "*Allegheny West Magazine* is an all positive, good news publication mailed free into the homes and businesses to connect communities, promote people, heighten awareness about the richness of the airport region, and build pride in the western suburbs of Allegheny County."

Our goals in 2012 included increasing our social media presence by adding more postings on our Facebook page, and communicating more regularly with our advertisers and local businesses through an e-mail newsletter program called Constant Contact. Consider "liking" our Facebook page so you, too, can get updates in between magazine issues.

We hope we are doing our job to serve you well. And, we hope to continue that effort through 2013.

Happy New Year!

Pat Jennette, Publisher & Editor

### Uncovering the History of Oil in Our Towns

A little over a hundred years ago, our region just west of Pittsburgh was a major source of oil production; one of the largest in the world, in fact. For the past few months, we've been running a series of articles on this little known facet of our local history, by focusing on the role each of the areas our magazine covers played in that oil boom. For the West Allegheny version, we looked at how oil built an entire town. For the Montour edition, we examined the role the geology underlying Robinson Township played. For this final installment in our Moon edition, we looked at what happened to oil production in the township in the years following.

If you're curious, you can read the other two versions in our archives on our Web site. It's a series that seemed appropriate given our recent natural gas boom, which has some economic and socio-logical parallels, and even shares some geologic commonalities. This most recent boom adds yet another chapter to an already long and rather complicated history of cultivating natural resources in a region that will likely see this industry operating here well into the future.



Doug Hughey, Assistant Editor

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# Oil Wells Helped Define This Region

*For the past four years, the U.S. has experienced a boom in natural gas production, thanks in part to advancements in techniques allowing drillers to burrow sideways through relatively narrow layers of rock thousands of feet below the surface. Coupled with a process known as hydraulic fracturing, which employs massive amounts of pressurized sand, water, and chemicals to break apart rock layers, drillers have recovered copious quantities of natural gas; so much now that usage at power plants is beginning to rival that of coal. As rising natural gas reserves have depressed methane prices, however, drillers have increasingly been focusing on areas like southwestern*

*Pennsylvania, where shale deposits contain larger ratios of valuable pentanes with prices tied to oil. Currently, natural gas derivatives recovered from the Marcellus Shale in the region are being processed both into fuels and consumer products from plastics to tires.*

*Over a hundred years ago, oil speculators descending on this same area were similarly in search of the raw building blocks for consumer products, at that time being demanded by markets arising from the industrial revolution. A decade before the advent of the Model T, when a byproduct of petroleum distillation known as gasoline was often dumped in rivers, most of the oil produced in Pennsylvania was being sold as kerosene to markets as far away as Europe and Russia. Packed with hydrogen-heavy paraffins, and low in impurities, Pennsylvania crude was suited to a range of products, and from it companies produced everything from bubblegum to machine lubricants. Some Pennsylvania-based motor oil companies still deal in high-paraffin crude produced from century-old wells like those operating across the region today.*

*By the time oil wells were sunk across parts of Robinson and Moon townships in the late 1880s, a feverish oil boom had already swept across western Pennsylvania. At least one Pennsylvania State Geologist was warning that the state's reserves had become tenuous, fueling a new breed of muckraking journalists in New York who decried the nation's growing dependence on a limited natural resource controlled by a consolidated sphere of wealth. It was a characterization, formulated largely around the monopolizing operations of John D. Rockefeller's Standard Oil in western Pennsylvania, that persists to this day.*

*When oil was first discovered in parts of Robinson Township in 1888, it set off a short-lived boom that spread across Moon Township and Crafton. Gushers discovered just a few miles further south set records still standing in*

*the Appalachian Basin today. By 1891, drillers were producing from an area stretching from Venice to Neville Island, and producing 12 million barrels of oil in a 12-month period. Pennsylvania's annual production swelled to an all-time high of 31.4 million barrels, only to taper off dramatically towards the turn of the century.*

*As the flow of oil from one of the last great fields in Pennsylvania history slowed to a trickle, oil interests set their sites westward. Over the next century, production in the region increasingly fell from large companies to small-time producers, some of whom are still operating those same wells today.*

John Kennedy remembers the farms that used to sit where Pittsburgh International Airport does today and the affluent families who occupied the mansions across town from where his father built homes for coal miners. He remembers the neighborhood kids jumping the fence to an exclusive swimming hole in the hollow off Thorn Run Road near where the Crowne Plaza now sits, and the chicken coops that provided vital sustenance to a neighborhood living under a cloud of smoke from a smoldering coal mine.

Today, John's old neighborhood sits a stone's throw from Pittsburgh International Airport. His childhood home is long gone, demolished in the 1960s under eminent domain to make way for the airport expansion. Gone, too, are those farms, including a sprawling, 1,100-acre experimental dairy farm once operated by millionaire National Dairy founder Edward E. Rieck. A number of oil wells once operated on that farm, as did hundreds across Crafton, Coraopolis, and Moon. John remembers kids tapping into their holding tanks and filling up their cars that could run on crude oil. He remembers listening to roughnecks talk about the days when nitroglycerine was hauled in from Pittsburgh on wagons to stimulate wells, but sometimes exploded enroute. He has a picture someone gave him of one that did, and the crater it created, somewhere. For a time, John worked on some area oil wells himself, after retiring in the 1970s, for one of the last remaining oil producers in the area.

Like many of his childhood neighbors, John's livelihood was one that centered around industries created by the area's natural resources. He worked for 14 years at Neville



# Wells Still Dot the Local Countryside



**ABOVE AND LEFT:** You see them in unexpected places, and in some cases, they sit alongside the road as you drive by them. They're oil wells, and they represent remnants of a time in western Pennsylvania history when the oil boom defined how some of this area secured its place in history due to the economic boom the oil wells brought. Many of the local wells still put out oil, and are owned by individuals who tap their reserves regularly. These photos around the airport area communities were taken by photographer Christopher Rolinson, a photography professor at Point Park University and owner of StartPoint Media. Can you identify where they are?



Chemical, helping offload petroleum byproducts that Neville converted into resins used in a range of building materials and consumer products.

The company, according to its website, got its start processing waste from coke ovens feeding the wartime steel industry. It was an area where numerous petroleum refineries once processed crude oil recovered from a region hemmed in by the Ohio River. Coraopolis was once home to a number of these companies, and a population that exploded in concert with the late 1880s oil boom.

By the time John retired from Neville Chemical in the 1970s, a handful of small companies and individuals were still producing oil in the region. One he started working for in Moon named Kenny Hanks had himself worked for an oil company named South Penn for about ten years. Once operating under the umbrella of Standard Oil, South Penn had spun off into its own entity under anti-trust legislation, and after boosting production for a time by injecting gas into its wells in the area in 1920s, had sold off their last remaining ones in 1949.

About 15 or so local interests purchased those wells, which in the booming postwar years were increasingly being encroached upon by a developing landscape. Part of John's job was to move

some of the century-old lines running to Kenny's wells to make way for roads and continuing development, or extract them altogether and construct holding tanks. He dismantled rigs for some producers, who let him keep parts as a form of payment. A wheel from one such rig currently sits in his front yard, which he painted red. He has it displayed as a leftover from an industry that, even by that time, had become obscure. He remembers, for instance, one day how he was excavating a line in a field behind where K-Mart sits today off Beaver Grade Road, and a police officer stopping to ask what he was doing. When John told him that an oil well was in the area, he didn't believe him.

John says that Kenny eventually sold his wells to a former engineer named Jim Meyers, who not only took over those wells but tried drilling his own, to no avail. A hole drilled near an existing, producing well he'd acquired turned out to be dry; a costly mistake considering not only the price of drilling, but also of removing the thousands of feet of casing.

Increasing development and environmental regulations spelled the death knell for many area wells. Some became inaccessible when the adjacent property was sold. Others were bought and plugged by developers, or rendered profitless when Pennsylvania passed its Oil and Gas Code in 1985. The Code outlawed a rather common practice of dumping potentially toxic saltwater brine produced with oil into streams and rivers. It also required producers to remove thousands of feet of casing to plug a well. As a result, some were simply abandoned.

For 95-year-old Moon resident Harris Wachter, who grew up drilling oil and gas wells with his father, the developing landscape created an opportunity to profit using his drilling experience. Harris grew up in Ingomar, helping his father build drill rigs, lay pipelines, and cut down trees for rig foundations, all by hand.

"It was a rough old racket," he said.

The elder Wachter started drilling wells in the early part of the century, much with the use of just one leg. The other he lost when it got caught in a giant, eight-foot bull wheel; the kind used by early oil and gas drillers to lift and plunge a 16-inch bit into the earth. Far from the oil fields underlying Robinson and Moon townships, most of what Harris' father recovered was natural gas, which at one time he sold to about 220 households from 20 wells.

After serving in World War II, Harris was hired back and then summarily laid off by Neville Island-based barge builder, Dravo. Looking for work, he began applying oil production techniques to drilling water wells for new homes across Moon and adjacent areas in the 1950s.

"My whole life I spent either working or trying to make a job," said Harris.

There's one well still out there, Harris said, that reminds of the old-time ones he used to build. It sits down by the Marriott off the Parkway, pictured above left, propped on the side of an embankment. It's owned by Ray Langer, whose father worked a number of wells in the area, just like his father before him. Well over a century old, it still pumps a half dozen barrels of crude per week.

"That's why he built it," said Harris, referring to the derrick. "He wants to show people how it was done."



PHOTOS BY CHRISTOPHER ROLINSON